CLOTH-BOUND CHEDDAR



THE BASICS

MAKE:	Hard
SUB MAKE:	Cheeses which acidify in the vat
POST-MAKE:	Wrapped, Rolled or Processed
SUB POST-MAKE:	Natural (leaf wrapped, wood or cloth girdle)
TYPICAL AGE PROFILE:	Three to 24 months
APPROXIMATE WEIGHT(S):	Typically 25kg truckles
GEOGRAPHICAL ORIGIN:	UK, but the name 'cheddar' is not protected so is used in many countries throughout the world
PROTECTED STATUS:	PDO for West Country Farmhouse Cheddar for cheeses made in Somerset, Dorset, Devon or Cornwall and matured for a minimum of nine months
SPECIES OF MILKING ANIMAL:	Cow
RAW/PASTEURISED MILK:	Examples of both depending on cheesemaker
VEGETARIAN/ANIMAL RENNET:	Examples of both depending on cheesemaker
COMMONLY ENCOUNTERED VARIATIONS:	N/A

THE STORY

Cheddar takes its name from a gorge and village in Somerset, where the cheese was first linked to as far back as the 16th century. There are many different shapes, sizes, colours and ages of cheddar, using different milks, made all over the world. However, the traditional cheese is made in round truckles using cows' milk, which are bandaged in muslin to protect them as they mature.

Following the hard cheese process, the curds are cut, stirred and scalded to temperatures around 38-42°C to remove moisture. The whey is drained, and the piles of curd are cut into blocks which are turned and stacked (cheddared) to promote drainage as they acidify. Once the target acidity is reached, the curds are milled and salted before moulding and pressing. The muslin is traditionally applied using lard. Natural moulds grow on the cloth during maturation and contribute to the development of the rind.

THE CHARACTER

The texture and flavour depend greatly on who made the cheese and how long it is matured. Young cheddars are smooth and tender with sweet, dairy notes, while mature cheeses can develop calcium lactate crystals and a firm, brittle texture with deep savoury notes.

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PERFECT PARTNERS:

Beer is best from golden ales and bitters to IPAs and Belgian farmhouse beers.

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